



RIPHAH
INTERNATIONAL UNIVERSITY



RIPHAH
DEPARTMENT OF ISLAMIC STUDIES

Basic Features of Modern Ideologies

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Objectives of the lecture

- To know the basic features of modern ideologies such as materialism, secularism, democracy, nationalism and humanism.
- To learn the impact of these modern ideologies on human life.
- To learn Islamic viewpoint about these ideologies.

Basic Questions...

What is materialism?

What is secularism?

What is democracy?

What is nationalism?

What is humanism?

What Islam argues about these theories or ideologies?



Materialism: Viewpoint about metaphysical world

Materialism is a philosophical system that regards matter as the only reality in the world. It attempts to explain every event in the universe as resulting from the conditions and activity of matter, and thus denies the existence of God and the immaterial soul. From this statement seen, materialism is a thought based on matter.*

Its an understanding that states that something invisible (can't be sensed) did not exist. That is, the unseen world (including God, angels, jinn, etc.) does not exist. Because it can't be sensed by humans.**

*Heidi A. Campbell and Heather Looy, *a Science and Religion Primer*, (USA: Baker Academic, 2009), p. 139

**(The Islamic Vision of Life, Vol. I, Page:99. By Khurshid Ahmad)



Materialism: Viewpoint about ethics & morality

Materialism is a tendency to prefer material possessions and physical comfort to spiritual values; a way of life based on material interests. *

Islam says that this life and its luxuries are nothing, but a test and the real life is hereafter.

Allah says in the Quran:

زُيِّنَ لِلنَّاسِ حُبُّ الشَّهَوَاتِ مِنَ النِّسَاءِ وَالْبَنِينَ وَالْقَنَاطِيرِ الْمُقَنْطَرَةِ مِنَ الذَّهَبِ وَالْفِصَّةِ وَالْخَيْلِ الْمُسَوَّمَةِ وَالْأَنْعَامِ وَالْحَرْثِ ذَلِكَ مَتَاعُ الْحَيَاةِ الدُّنْيَا وَاللَّهُ عِنْدَهُ حُسْنُ الْمَاَبِ (14)

Men are naturally tempted by the lure of women, children, treasures of gold and silver, horses of mark, cattle and plantations. These are the enjoyments in the life of this world; but with Allah lies a goodly abode to return to. (*Al-Imran; 3:14*)

*Charles T. Tart, *The End of Materialism: How Evidence of the Paranormal is Bringing Science and Spirit Together*, (USA: Harbinger Publications, 2009), p. 295



Islamic Views and critique of materialism

Materialism is unacceptable in Islam because materialism revolt against the Lord and against the realities beyond the understanding of human perception. Materialism is also against the prophethood, as it does not believe in God, also does not believe in anything related to God. While human needs a guidance to know about the creator of universe and its laws and rules related to life.

The concept of materialism blinding us from knowing the truth.

Also, materialism contrary to the core teachings of Islam, especially related to the concept of monotheism (Tauhid). The six articles of faith in Islam are metaphysical and undetected by a naked eye.

Therefore, the need of prophethood is highlighted in the Holy Quran as follows.

هُوَ الَّذِي بَعَثَ فِي الْأُمِّيِّينَ رَسُولًا مِنْهُمْ يَتْلُو عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتِهِ وَيُزَكِّيهِمْ وَيُعَلِّمُهُمُ الْكِتَابَ وَالْحِكْمَةَ وَإِنْ كَانُوا مِنْ قَبْلُ لَفِي ضَلَالٍ مُبِينٍ.

“He it is Who has raised a Messenger among the gentiles' from among themselves, who recites to them His Revelations, purifies them and teaches them the Book and the Wisdom, whereas before this they were indeed lost in manifest error.”

(Al-Jumu'ah 62/2)



Materialism and Islam

Materialism is not in accordance with Islam. The teachings of materialism are contrary to the core teachings of Islam; believing in the Creator. Materialism also contrary to human nature, because in their essence, humans are worshipers.

إِنَّمَا أَمْوَالُكُمْ وَأَوْلَادُكُمْ فِتْنَةٌ

“Your riches and your children are but a trial” (Al-Taghabun: 64/15)

يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تُلْهِكُمْ أَمْوَالُكُمْ وَلَا أَوْلَادُكُمْ عَنْ ذِكْرِ اللَّهِ وَمَنْ يَفْعَلْ ذَلِكَ فَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْخَاسِرُونَ

“O you who believe, your riches and your children must not divert you from the remembrance of Allah. And those who do that are the losers”

(Al-Taghabun: 64/15)



Secularism

Secularism is based on following three principles

- 1.Separation** of religious institutions from state institutions and a public sphere where religion may participate, but not dominate.
- 2.Freedom** to practice one's faith or belief without harming others, or to change it or not have one, according to one's own conscience.
- 3.Equality** so that religious beliefs or lack of them doesn't put anyone at an advantage or a disadvantage.

<https://www.secularism.org.uk/what-is-secularism.html>



Quran and Secularism

Supporters of Secularism state that, politics and religion should be separated because religion is a private matter while politics is a public affair. According to this argument politics and religion constitute two different kingdoms of reality. Religion is about spirituality while politics focuses upon the material aspects of the life. For this reason, religion cannot play any public role in state affairs. Quran describes this as:

قَالُوا يَا شُعَيْبُ أَصَلَاتُكَ تَأْمُرُكَ أَنْ نَتْرِكَ مَا يَعْبُدُ آبَاؤُنَا أَوْ أَنْ نَفْعَلَ فِي أَمْوَالِنَا مَا نَشَاءُ إِنَّكَ لَأَنْتَ الْحَلِيمُ الرَّشِيدُ

They said, :O Shu'aib, does your Salah (prayer) command you that we should forsake what our fathers used to worship or that we should not deal with our wealth as we please? You pretend to be the only man of wisdom and guidance.

(Hud: 11/87)



Islamic viewpoint about Secularism

Islam has never accepted the view that religion is a private matter between a man and his creator as Quran is a complete code of life, it guides in all matters, religious or social, civil or criminal, military or penal, economic or commercial. It regulates every act, speech or movement from the ceremonies of religion to those of daily life, from the salvation of soul to health of body, from the rights of all to those of such individual, from the punishment here to that in the life to come.

قُلْ إِنَّ صَلَاتِي وَنُسُكِي وَمَحْيَايَ وَمَمَاتِي لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ

“Say: 'Surely my Prayer, all my acts of worship, and my living and my dying are for Allah alone, the Lord of the whole universe’”

(Al-Ana'am: 6/162)



Democracy

Democracy is a composite of two Greek words: demos, meaning the masses or the people, and kratia, meaning rule. So, what is meant is the rule of the masses or the rule of the people.

Democracy is a system that is contrary to Islam, because it gives the power of legislation to the people or to those who represent them (such as members of Parliament). Based on that, in democracy legislative authority is given to someone other than Allah; rather it is given to the people and their deputies, and what matters is not their consensus but the majority. Thus, what the majority agree upon becomes laws that are binding on the nation, even if it is contrary to common sense, religious teaching or reason. In this system laws, policies, leadership, and major undertakings of a state or other polity are directly or indirectly decided by the “people”.

<https://islamqa.info/en/answers/98134/concept-of-democracy-in-islam>



Islamic Views and critique of democracy

Allah almighty has told us in the His Book that legislative authority belongs to Him alone, and that He is the wisest of those who issue rulings and judge. He has forbidden the association of anyone with Him in His authority, and no one is better than Him in ruling.

﴿فَالْحُكْمُ لِلَّهِ الْعَلِيِّ الْكَبِيرِ﴾ سورة غافر: 12

“So the judgement is only with Allah, the Most High, the Most Great!” [Ghaafir 40:12]

﴿إِنِ الْحُكْمُ إِلَّا لِلَّهِ أَمَرَ أَلَّا تَعْبُدُوا إِلَّا إِيَّاهُ ذَلِكَ الدِّينُ الْقَيِّمُ وَلَكِنَّ أَكْثَرَ النَّاسِ لَا يَعْلَمُونَ﴾ سورة يوسف: 40

“The command (or the judgement) is for none but Allah. He has commanded that you worship none but Him (i.e. His Monotheism), that is the (true) straight religion, but most men know not” [Yoosuf 12:40]



Concept of Sovereignty in Democracy

In conventional democratic system, people are sovereign and superior, where laws are made with consultation without any divine guidance. But in Islamic Political System Sovereignty belongs to Allah Almighty, so no law can be made in contradiction with Quran and Sunnah. So, in Islamic democratic tradition Allah is law giver and he is supreme authority. As Quran describes:

إِنِ الْحُكْمُ إِلَّا لِلَّهِ

“The Decision belongs to none but Allah” (Al-Ana’m: 6/57)



Nationalism

The nation-state is the new phenomena, which divided the world into different nations and states and inspiring people to establish self-governing state.

Nationalism, ideology based on the premise that the individual's loyalty and devotion to the nation-state surpass other individual or group interests.*

It obliges excessive devotion to a nation, a colour, a race or an ethnic group.

* Kohn, Hans. "Nationalism". *Encyclopedia Britannica*, 28 Nov. 2020, <https://www.britannica.com/topic/nationalism>. Accessed 9 August 2021.



Islamic view on Nationalism

According to Allama Iqbal, Muslims constitute a nation on the basis of a common spiritual aspiration and not on the grounds of common language, race and territory.* Iqbal rejected the prevalent concept of Territorial Nationalism; he refuted the concept on the basis of its contradiction with Islam and it is modern form idolatry. Allama Iqbal explains that the concept of territorial nationalism divides the nations of world. The concept of territorial nationalism has changed the course of politics and economy. The objective and aims of politics and economy to take-over the other nation's land and resources and destruction of houses of poor. Iqbal's main argument was against the western concept of linguistic and racial nationalism. Therefore, he supported the Muslim nationalism which is based on spiritual homogeneity.

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Islamic view on Nationality and State

According to Islam a person's adherence and devotion should stem from right creed and piety.

يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ إِنَّا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ مِنْ ذَكَرٍ وَأُنْثَىٰ وَجَعَلْنَاكُمْ شُعُوبًا وَقَبَائِلَ لِتَعَارَفُوا إِنَّ أَكْرَمَكُمْ عِنْدَ اللَّهِ أَتْقَاكُمْ

O mankind, We have created you from a male and a female, and made you into races and tribes, so that you may identify one another. Surely the noblest of you, in Allah's sight, is the one who is most pious of you. (Al-Hujurat: 49/13)



Humanism

- Humanism is a philosophy that stresses the importance of human factors rather than looking at religious, divine, or spiritual matters. Humanism is rooted in the idea that people have an ethical responsibility to lead lives that are personally fulfilling while at the same time contributing to the greater good for all people.*
- Humanism stresses the importance of human values and dignity. It proposes that people can resolve problems using science and reason. Rather than looking to religious traditions, humanism instead focuses on helping people live well, achieve personal growth, and make the world a better place.
- *. Kendra Cherry , “What is Humanistic psychology”, *Very Well Mind*, [https://www.verywellmind.com/what-is-humanistic-psychology-2795242#:~:text=Humanism%20is%20a%20philosophy%20that,%2C%20divine%2C%20or%20spiritual%20matters.&text=Rather%20than%20looking%20to%20religious,the%20world%20a%20better%20place.\(09-08-2021\)](https://www.verywellmind.com/what-is-humanistic-psychology-2795242#:~:text=Humanism%20is%20a%20philosophy%20that,%2C%20divine%2C%20or%20spiritual%20matters.&text=Rather%20than%20looking%20to%20religious,the%20world%20a%20better%20place.(09-08-2021))



Islam and Humanism

It must be clearly understood that **Islam does not oppose any human values, or human rights**; and what it objects to is the negation of God to emphasize the authority of Man in the universe, which is the underlying philosophy of secular humanism; and this Islam rejects.

وَلَقَدْ كَرَّمْنَا بَنِي آدَمَ وَحَمَلْنَاهُمْ فِي الْبَرِّ وَالْبَحْرِ وَرَزَقْنَاهُمْ مِنَ الطَّيِّبَاتِ وَفَضَّلْنَاهُمْ عَلَى كَثِيرٍ مِمَّنْ خَلَقْنَا تَفْضِيلًا

And We bestowed dignity on the children of ‘Adam and provided them with rides on the land and in the sea and provided them with a variety of good things and made them much superior to many of those whom We have created.

(Al-Isra: 17/70)



Islam and Humanism

- According to Islam, for man to be really free, he should be true to his origin and his basic nature. This is possible only when he consciously acknowledges his true Creator, the source of all essence and existence.
- Only by being subservient to his True God can Man be truly free. In other words, only by being a slave and servant to His Creator can he/she be free. If he/she rebels against his/her Creator, Who is Infinite, he/she becomes a slave of some finite god.



Islam and Humanism

عَنْ أَبِي هُرَيْرَةَ، أَنَّ رَسُولَ اللَّهِ صَلَّى اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِ وَسَلَّمَ قَالَ " حَقُّ الْمُسْلِمِ عَلَى الْمُسْلِمِ سِتُّ " . قِيلَ مَا هُنَّ يَا رَسُولَ اللَّهِ قَالَ " إِذَا لَقَيْتَهُ فَسَلِّمْ عَلَيْهِ وَإِذَا دَعَاكَ فَأَجِبْهُ وَإِذَا اسْتَنْصَحَكَ فَانْصَحْ لَهُ وَإِذَا عَطَسَ فَحَمِدَ اللَّهَ فَسَمِّتْهُ وَإِذَا مَرِضَ فَعُدَّهُ وَإِذَا مَاتَ فَاتَّبِعْهُ "

Abu Huraira reported Allah's Messenger ﷺ saying:

Six are the rights of a Muslim over another Muslim. It was said to him: Allah's Messenger, what are these? Thereupon he said: When you meet him, offer him greetings; when he invites you to a feast accept it. when he seeks your council give him, and when he sneezes and says: " All praise is due to Allah," you say Yarhamuk Allah (may Allah show mercy to you) ; and when he falls ill visit him; and when he dies follow his bier.

Sahih Muslim: 2162



Summary

Materialism is a system which completely denies the existence of unseen world including the existence of Creator Allah. It focuses on material aspect of universe. Aside from this, secularism accepts the religion but only at personal level, religion and state are two separate entities in secularism. Islam also has its own view on nationalism and humanism as Islamic nationalism is based on spiritual homogeneity rather than race, language or territorial base. Some modern Islamic thinkers rejected the notion of democracy as a foreign idea incompatible with Islam. Others have argued that traditional Islamic notions such as shura (consultation), masalaha (public interest), and adle (justice) justify representative government institutions which are similar to democracy but reflect Islamic rather than Western liberal values.